COACHING IN PRACTICE

Coaching Conversations

How a coaching conversation brings the skills together: agreeing its purpose, exploring, converging on a next step, staying in the coaching stance, and practising in a coaching dojo.

What a coaching conversation is for

A coaching conversation is where the skills from the other resources come together: curiosity, listening, powerful questions and observation. It helps the other person think more clearly about a situation that matters to them and find their own next step. The content belongs to the coachee. The coach is responsible for the process of the conversation.

A coaching conversation can be a planned session, but it can also be ten minutes after a meeting or a question in the corridor. What makes it a coaching conversation is not the setting but the stance: the coach helps the other person find their own answer instead of giving one.

Agree the purpose

Start by agreeing what the conversation is for. Ask what the other person would like to get out of it, and how much time you have. A conversation with a single, clear purpose is more productive than one that tries to cover everything, so if several topics come up, agree which one to work on now and which ones to take to a separate conversation.

Useful opening questions include "What would you like to talk about?", "What would make this conversation useful for you?" and "What would you like to have at the end of our time together?"

Explore before you converge

Most coaching conversations first open up and then narrow down. In the opening, divergent part, the coach helps the coachee explore the situation. Listen at Level II or Level III, write down keywords, use support responses and ask about what seems to matter most. Detective and anthropologist questions from Karl Tomm's model help to understand what happened and how others might see it.

Once the situation is clearer, the conversation moves towards options and action. Scientist questions explore possibilities, and captain questions turn them into a concrete next step: "What will you do first?", "Who do you need to involve?", "How will you know it has worked?" Close by checking that the coachee has what they wanted from the conversation.

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Watch the balance between the two parts. Converging too early leads to solutions for a problem that is not yet understood. Staying open for too long leaves the coachee with more questions than they came with.

Stay in the coaching stance

During a conversation, it is tempting to step out of the coaching stance, especially into advising or teaching. Sometimes that is right, for example when the coachee lacks information they need. Notice when you switch, and find your way back with a question, such as "What do you make of that?" or "Which of these options fits your situation best?" The resource on coaching stances describes the stances in detail.

Also notice when you are steering the conversation towards a topic that interests you rather than the coachee, or offering advice nobody asked for. Both are signs that you are listening at Level I.

Reframe negative statements

Coachees often describe what they do not want: "The meetings are a waste of time" or "I don't want to be the one who always decides". It helps to invite them to rephrase these statements in positive terms: "What would you like the meetings to achieve instead?" or "How would you like decisions to be made?" A positive formulation describes something the coachee can work towards, which makes it much easier to find a next step.

Practise in a coaching dojo

A coaching dojo is a safe space to practise and reflect on coaching skills. One person, the coachee, brings a real case they would like support with. A coach uses the opportunity to practise coaching techniques, and one or more observers give feedback afterwards. Because dojos work best with real cases rather than invented ones, they require respectful communication and confidentiality. A dojo needs at least three people.

1. Everyone thinks of a challenge they currently face, and the group chooses one. The problem owner becomes the coachee, and a volunteer becomes the coach. The others observe, with a focus agreed beforehand, for example stance changes, powerful questions or keywords.
2. The coach and coachee have a coaching conversation of about seven minutes.
3. The observers give feedback for about three minutes. What did they notice? What worked well, and what could the coach try next time?
4. Change roles and repeat.

Afterwards, reflect as a group. Did the conversation have a clear purpose? How did the coach move between exploring and converging? Did the coach notice keywords and follow the coachee's interest? What did the conversation lead to: a solution, another outcome or a follow-up conversation?

Further reading

- Whitmore, J.: Coaching for Performance. Introduces the GROW model (goal, reality, options, will), a widely used structure for coaching conversations.
- Stanier, M. B.: The Coaching Habit. Seven questions for everyday coaching conversations, with a focus on staying curious longer.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/coaching-skills/coaching-conversations